

Future star: Kashvee Gautam, the most expensive uncapped Indian player in WPL history, showcased her skills in her debut season, justifying the investment with glimpses of promise. SPORTZPICS

announced. A tentative list of venues for the Women's ODI World Cup — set to be hosted by India later this year — was also revealed. The absence of mainstream cricketing venues left everyone stunned. Visakhapatnam, Thiruvananthapuram, Guwahati, Indore, and Mullanpur have been selected as initial candidates to host the women's showpiece event.

This selection made the venue experiment during the WPL seem futile. Imagine the atmosphere of an India vs Australia fixture with 30,000-odd fans shaking the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru. South Africa's 2024 tour of India highlighted Chennai's warm embrace of women's cricket, with crowds cheering both teams with equal passion. Why wouldn't India's best venues — weather permitting — be automatic choices for a world event?

The simultaneous scheduling of men's bilaterals and domestic matches may explain the decision. However, former players and coaches, speaking anonymously, argue that non-traditional venues need a starting point to evolve into major cricketing hubs like Mumbai, Delhi, Chennai, Kolkata, and Bengaluru. India will host the tournament for the fourth time. In 1978, matches were played across Calcutta, Hyderabad, Jamshedpur, and Patna. The 1997 edition spanned 20 cities, while 2013 was limited to just Cuttack and Mumbai.

"We've played games in cities like Dhanbad (Jharkhand), and there was no issue of attendance. People sat on trees to watch us play. You might be surprised by how many turn up this time, especially with the World Cup tag attached," a former player told



LISTEN TO OUR
PODCAST

THE WPL IS NO LONGER JUST A STEPPING STONE TO THE NATIONAL TEAM. FOR MANY DOMESTIC PLAYERS, IT HAS BECOME A STANDALONE CAREER GOAL



this publication. Mithali emphasised how the WPL has given women's cricket a level of visibility it never had before.

"Premium women's cricket in the WPL now has a prime-time slot — 7:30 pm — which has become appointment viewing. It's not like afternoon games; there's one match per day to make it easy for both stadium audiences and home viewers. People want to watch the stars they're seeing on TV," she noted.

ICC chair Jay Shah tweeted early in the season that the first leg of the WPL saw a 150 per cent surge in TV ratings and 70 per cent growth in digital viewership compared to the previous season. If any proof was needed that the WPL is a product people want to return to, this is it.

Assembly line

With the first cycle of the league complete, the WPL has already had a significant impact. Several players have risen from the league's grind to the national side — Asha Sobhana, Shreyanka Patil, Saika Ishaque, Saima Thakor, and Sajeevan Sajana, to name a few. However, fitness and form have kept them from securing